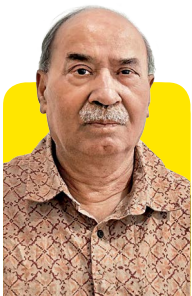


Expectations from Union Budget 2024-25

● It is expected that the upcoming Union Budget will include several measures to generate more employment opportunities

- 1 BOOST PRIVATE INVESTMENTS AND TWEAK PLI SCHEME TO INCLUDE MORE SECTORS
- 2 PLI SCHEME COULD BE LINKED TO MSMEs THAT ALSO CREATE JOBS
- 3 APPRENTICESHIP SCHEME COULD BE REVIEWED TO BRING JOB OPPORTUNITIES FOR EDUCATED YOUTH
- 4 RURAL FOCUS WITH MORE FUNDS FOR ROAD CONSTRUCTION, WELFARE SCHEMES, AND AGRICULTURE
- 5 SCHEMES TO BOOST WOMEN'S PARTICIPATION IN WORKFORCE, FLEXIBLE WORKING



“The central problem of unemployment in India is that of youth unemployment, especially amongst those who are educated; and the low female labour force participation rate”

ALAKH N. SHARMA
PROFESSOR AND DIRECTOR, INSTITUTE
FOR HUMAN DEVELOPMENT

dustry absorbing them eventually. Enrolment of apprentices rose to 930,000 in FY24 from 738,000 in the year-ago period. “The scheme can be tweaked to make it more attractive for young school and college graduates to get on-the-job training,” says Mahajan.

Sumit Kumar, Chief Strategy Officer at TeamLease Degree Apprenticeship, which runs degree apprenticeship programmes, had earlier called for linking apprenticeship with higher education through degree apprenticeships under the New Education Policy. “Additionally, we need to establish an apprenticeship credit framework for lateral entry to higher education, tailor schemes for MSMEs to embrace apprenticeships, promote adult apprenticeships for lifelong learning, and scale up support mechanisms like TPAs (third-party aggregators), which have significantly contributed to the growth of NAPS,” he had said.

The other concern is to boost women's participation in the labour force. According to IHD's Sharma, this is a must as there are high rates of unemployment among educated women. “There are a number of factors for this ranging from security and safety concerns to household and care work,” he says. He suggests that the Budget should include measures to facilitate flexible work for women, apart from the gig economy, as well as enhance allocations for facilities like working women's hostels and crèches so that more of them can join the workforce.

Pre-Budget suggestions from experts also include a possible robot tax for jobs that have been impacted by the rise of AI. Mahajan had mooted the proposal for such a tax. “Can we impose a tax on AI that is not giving too much efficiency but reducing jobs? This money can then be used for skilling workers and redeploying them,” he adds.

There are also hopes that the Budget will announce filling up of vacancies in government jobs, an issue that trade unions had raised in their pre-Budget discussions. The Bharatiya Mazdoor Sangh, which is affiliated to the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh, has pegged vacancies in the central government at 2 million and has demanded that these be filled up quickly. While the exact contours of the Union Budget and its proposals are likely to be finalised in the coming days, experts caution that employment-related policies often take months, if not years, to make an impact at the ground level. But given that India is likely to have the largest share of working-age population by 2030, giving a boost to employment now would hold the country in good stead later. **BT**

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